Swiggy Smart Delay Alert: Case Study

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Executive Summary

Problem: 5-20% of Swiggy orders experience 30+ minute delays with zero proactive communication, driving ~500K frustrated customers daily to competitors.

Solution: Smart Delay Alert — AI-driven feature predicting delays, notifying users proactively, and offering immediate choices (cancel free or wait for ₹50 credit).

Impact: +10% on-time delivery perception, -15% support reduction, +5 NPS points

Timeline: 4-6 week delivery (vs 12+ months for ops-only solutions)

Problem

The Reality

Real User Quote 1:

> "I ordered at 11 PM, expected by 11:40, waited >1 hour. Support took 25 minutes to connect, only offered a refund after 1 hour – **not accountability**."

Real User Quote 2:

> "Tracking showed 'delivery partner at your location' but they were actually 30 km away delivering another order."

Real User Quote 3:

> "Waited 4 hours total (2 hours delivery + 2 hours support). They offered a **₹19 coupon on a ₹450 order** – essentially telling me my frustration is worth ₹19."

Real User Quote 4:

"Support blamed 'peak hour' delay on a **Tuesday at 10:42 PM**" — no context, no empathy.

The Scale

- **5-20% of orders** experience 30+ minute delays (2-3x over promised ETA)
- **~500,000 frustrated customers daily** (at 10M orders/day scale)
- **360 million incident orders per year** (10% failure rate on 3.6B annual orders)
- **Support overload**: Each delayed order = 1 support ticket (25-45 min wait)

Root Causes (From 500+ Complaints Analysis)

NOT just logistics. Analysis revealed:

1. **No proactive communication** — Users wait silently, discover delays too late
2. **Misleading ETA & tracking** — App shows wrong location or outdated status
3. **Inadequate compensation** — ₹19-₹50 coupons on ₹300-₹1,000 orders
4. **Slow/scripted support** — 25-45 min waits, "peak hour" excuses, no escalation
5. **Rigid cancellation policies** — Users charged fees despite Swiggy failure
6. **Cold/stale food** — Quality suffers from delays
7. **Refund processing delays** — 7+ days to hit account

The Insight

Most companies would say: "We need more riders! Better routing! Faster restaurants!"

Research revealed: Users don't mind delays if they have **transparency, control, and fair compensation**.

The problem isn't delays. The problem is **communication**.

💡 Solution: Smart Delay Alert & Options

How It Works (5 Steps)

STEP 1: Predict Delay

- AI model uses real-time data: traffic, rider speed, restaurant prep time
- Continuously updates predicted delivery time
- Triggers alert when delay > 20 min with 80% confidence

STEP 2: Notify Proactively

- Red banner appears on tracking screen at ~45-minute mark
- Push notification sent simultaneously
- Message: "Your order is delayed by ~20 minutes due to high demand. New ETA: 7:50 PM"

STEP 3: User Chooses

- **Option A**: "Cancel Order (No Fee)" → Refund issued immediately, zero cancellation fee
- **Option B**: "I'll Wait (Get ₹50 credit)" → Credit applied on delivery (10% of order value)

STEP 4: Execute

- **If cancel**: ₹450 refunded to account in seconds, special offer coupon (₹50 off next order)
- **If wait**: Credit applied on delivery, gratitude message, rate order prompt

STEP 5: Close Loop

- User either re-orders from Swiggy or continues happily
- Data collected to improve alert model

The 5 Wireframe Screens

Screen 1: Normal Tracking (Before Delay) Shows promised ETA (7:30 PM), delivery partner info, order summary. No alert needed.

Screen 2: Delay Alert Banner ⭐ THE KEY SCREEN

- **Red banner** with: "Your order is delayed by ~20 minutes due to high demand. New ETA: 7:50 PM"
- **Two buttons**: "Cancel Order (No Fee)" | "I'll Wait (Get ₹50 credit)"
- **Why it matters**: This ONE screen solves 3 major pain points:
    1. No communication ✓
    2. No user choice ✓
    3. No compensation ✓

Screen 3A: Cancel Confirmation Modal Confirms refund (₹450), explicitly states "No cancellation fee", shows refund timeline.

- Solves: "They charged me cancellation fee despite Swiggy failure"

Screen 3B: Wait Confirmation Modal "Thanks for waiting!" with credit breakdown (Order: ₹450, Credit: ₹50, Effective: ₹400).

- Solves: "I waited 4 hours and got ₹19 coupon. That's insulting."

Screen 4: Cancellation Confirmation Refund details, transaction ID, timeline. Special offer: "₹50 off your next order"

- Message: "We're sorry about the delay. Hope to serve you better next time."

Screen 5: Delivery Success with Credit "Order Delivered! ✓ ₹50 credit added to your account"

- Green success banner showing credit was applied
- Message: "Thank you for your patience!"

Why This Solves the Problem

Problem	**Current Approach**	**Smart Alert Solution**
No communication	Silent wait	Proactive alert at 45-min mark
Misleading ETA	Shows original promise	Updates with real ETA
No choice	Cancel (charged) or suffer	Cancel free OR wait+credit
Inadequate compensation	₹19 after escalation	₹50 (10% of order) auto-applied
Support overload	25+ min queue	Automated, no contact needed
Lost trust	Feels disrespected	Feels heard & valued

Why This Approach is Unique

1. Data-Driven Problem Diagnosis

- Analyzed **500+ complaints** from Reddit, Quora, Trustpilot
- Identified **7 major complaint themes**
- Diagnosed root cause: **Communication, not logistics**
- **Most competitors**: Focus on speed. We focused on **trust**.

2. India-Specific Insights

- Swiggy One distance inflation (users caught paying fees despite membership)
- "Peak hour" excuses even on Tuesdays (no context awareness)
- Inadequate compensation culture (₹19-₹50 coupons on ₹300-₹1,000 orders)
- **Not a generic copy** of Uber Eats or DoorDash

3. Multi-Lever Solution

- **Detection**: AI predicts delays
- **Communication**: Proactive alert
- **Policy**: No cancellation fee
- **Compensation**: Fair % of order value
- **Most competitors**: Alert only. We address **policy + compensation + communication**.

4. PM-Owned End-to-End

- Ships in **4-6 weeks** (not 12 months like ops overhauls)
- Measurable from **day 1**
- Full PM lifecycle: **research → design → testing → metrics**
- Shows **ownership and design thinking**, not just feature requests

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Success Metrics

Primary KPIs

1. On-Time Delivery Rate

- Current: ~85-90% (estimated)
- Target: 95%+ (+10%)
- Measurement: Delivery timestamp vs promised ETA

2. Support Tickets for "Where is my order?"

- Current: 15-20% of all support volume
- Target: -15% reduction (eliminate 30K+ tickets monthly)
- Measurement: Support ticketing system tags

3. NPS Among Delayed Orders

- Current: 6-7 (for delayed orders)

- Target: 11-12 (+5 points)
- Measurement: Post-delivery survey

Secondary KPIs

4. User Action Distribution

- % who cancel via alert (expect 20-30%)
- % who wait via alert (expect 70-80%)

5. Repeat Order Rate

- Post-alert users should reorder sooner/more often than control
- Indicates: compensation + transparency worked

6. Compensation Cost

- Total credits issued / total order value
- Target: < 0.5% of GMV

A/B Test Design

- **Control**: Current Swiggy (no alerts)
- **Treatment**: With Smart Delay Alert
- **Sample**: 50,000 orders per group
- **Duration**: 2 weeks
- **Success gate**: Support tickets drop >10%, NPS increases >3 points

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Research Foundation

Complaint Themes Identified

1. **Hours-long delays with no notice** (HIGH frequency)
    - Users order 30 min, receive 1-3 hours late
    - No proactive updates
    - Impact: Missed plans, family waits, work disruption
2. **False/Misleading ETA** (HIGH frequency)
    - "At your location" but driver 30km away

    - Location spoofing, no real-time updates
    - Impact: Eroded trust in tracking system

3. **Inadequate compensation** (HIGH frequency)

    - ₹19-₹50 coupons on ₹300-₹1,000 orders
    - Compensation ≠ order value
    - Impact: Felt disrespected, not valued

4. **Slow/scripted support** (HIGH frequency)

    - 25-45 min wait times
    - "It's peak hour" excuses on Tuesdays
    - No empathy or escalation
    - Impact: Support queue became part of problem

5. **Rider unavailability** (MEDIUM-HIGH frequency)

    - No rider for 1+ hour after order
    - Mid-delivery reassignments
    - Impact: Cascading delays

6. **Cold/stale food** (MEDIUM frequency)

    - Quality suffers from delays
    - Cascades from other issues

7. **Refund processing delays** (MEDIUM frequency)

    - 7+ days to hit account
    - Some never received

Key Statistics

- **5-20% of orders** = 500K frustrated customers daily
- **Support wait**: 25-45 minutes average
- **Compensation gap**: ₹19 on ₹450 order (4% of order value)
- **Court cases**: Swiggy fined ₹35,000 for distance inflation (2024)
- **CCI findings**: Swiggy guilty of anticompetitive practices (Nov 2024)

Key Learnings

Learning 1: Communication Beats Logistics

Insight: Users tolerate delays if they know why and have options. Silence breeds frustration.

Most food delivery companies focus on speed (riders, routing). My research showed users will wait 1 hour if:

- Someone tells them upfront ("You'll be 20 min late, here's why")
- They have a choice ("Cancel or wait?")
- They get compensated fairly ("Here's ₹50 for your time")

Implication: Product thinking > ops thinking.

Learning 2: User Agency Rebuilds Trust

Insight: Give users control, not just information.

Just telling someone "you're late" doesn't solve it. Giving **immediate options** (cancel free OR wait+credit) transforms them from victims to decision-makers.

Implication: Don't just fix problems; give users power over outcomes.

Learning 3: Compensation Must Match Inconvenience

Insight: ₹19 on ₹450 is an insult. 10% of order value feels fair.

Implication: Compensation scales with impact.

Learning 4: Speed to Market Matters

Insight: 4-6 weeks shipping a communication feature beats 12 months optimizing logistics.

Can launch fast, measure immediately, iterate. Ops changes take forever.

Implication: Prioritize what you can ship and measure fast.

Conclusion

This project demonstrates **how user research and strategic thinking can solve real problems better than pure operations optimization**.

By analyzing complaints, identifying root causes (communication gaps), and designing a solution (proactive alerts + user choice + fair compensation), I created a feature that:

- Solves the #1 user pain point
- Ships in 4-6 weeks (not 12 months)
- Measures impact from day 1
- Scales trust instead of just speed

Key insight: Give users transparency and control, and they'll forgive delays.

Next Steps **Pilot in Bangalore** (1 city, 10% of orders) — Validate model, measure false alert rate

1. **Iterate based on data** — Adjust thresholds, refine copy, test compensation %
2. **Expand to metros** (A/B test 50K orders) — Measure all KPIs
3. **Full rollout nationwide** — Monitor daily, refine continuously, scale

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